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# The Mexican

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# The Mexican

It should have been dream casting: the babelicious Brad Pitt (though here for once not showing his abs) and Julia Roberts, whose career just now is hotter than Georgia asphalt. They team up for a comedy-thriller-road-movie, in a relationship pertly triangulated by no less a person than James Gandolfini, famed for his mob boss in *The Sopranos*, a screen event more admirable than anything Julia or Brad have ever been involved in.

But nothing in this implausible marriage of thrills and whimsy works, least of all the supposed chemistry between Brad and Julia, a relationship the film scuppers from the outset by having them spend most of the film's interminable 124 minutes apart. And when they are together, shouting, wheedling, murmuring and smirking lines of dialogue at each other, we are always uncomfortably aware that these people are actors who just don't know each other very well. They do not click; neither do they gel - like Ming-Ming and Bao-Bao, the resolutely celibate pandas of London Zoo. Julia can just about crank up some screen energy with her great split watermelon grin, but Brad is very poor, and his entrance riding a donkey in Mexico is a virtual masterclass in how not to do funny.

The motions they go through are these: Brad plays Jerry, a lovably incompetent non-violent hoodlum, who promises his feisty girlfriend Sam (Roberts) that he will quit dirty work for the Mob - but gets bullied into accepting one last job, picking up a valuable antique pistol south of the border known as *The Mexican*, which everyone is after. Sam storms off and is kidnapped by the burly-yet-cuddly hit-man Gandolfini. The plot has a lot of holes, and as a "McGuffin" to drive the plot, the Mexican pistol is irritatingly unconvincing. Why would any tough US mafioso want it so much? The answer is sentimental reasons, but these are very improbable and in any case left unclear until the end.

The most disappointing thing, maybe inevitably, is Gandolfini, whose tough guy turns out to be gay, sensitive, emotionally literate and unafraid to cry in front of a woman who deftly analyses him. It is an obvious and hamfisted attempt to deconstruct and reassemble the Tony Soprano package for a different audience. The cinema career of that other HBO star Garry Shandling has not taken off, and, sadly, there is no guarantee Gandolfini's won't be similarly earthbound.

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